KEY TOPIC 3: US INVOLVEMENT IN THE VIETNAM WAR, 1954–75

Paper 3: Conflict at Home and Abroad: the USA, 1954–75



COURSE TEXTBOOK

Contents

Lesson 1: KT 3.1: Why did the US support the unpopular government of Ngo Dinh Diem in South Vietnam?

Lesson 2: KT 3.2: Why did the US send combat troops to Vietnam after the Gulf of Tonkin incident?

Lesson 3: KT 3.3: Why did US military tactics (like bombing and search & destroy) fail to defeat the Vietcong?

Lesson 4: KT 3.4: What was Nixon's 'Vietnamization' policy, and did it achieve peace with honour?

L1: KT 3.1: Why did the US support the unpopular government of Ngo Dinh Diem in South Vietnam?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Demonstrate comprehensive historical knowledge of the key developments and figures in KT 3.1: Why did the US support the unpopular government of Ngo Dinh Diem in South Vietnam?.
- [ ] Analyse conflicting motivations, tactics, and responses of groups and individuals involved in the crisis.
- [ ] Evaluate competing historical interpretations and source evidence to construct reasoned causal judgments for Paper 3.

Recall & Retrieval

1. What sparked the Watts Riots in Los Angeles in 1965?

2. What did the Kerner Commission identify as the main cause of the riots?

3. How did the Kerner Report describe American society in 1968?

4. Which laws enforced racial segregation and discrimination in the Southern states in the 1950s?

5. What does the abbreviation NAACP stand for?

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: *Circle ONE term that does not belong with the others. Explain your reasoning: What historical connection links the other terms, and why is your chosen term different?*

17th Parallel | Strategic Hamlet Program | Domino Theory | Geneva Accords | Ngo Dinh Diem

Teacher Model / Pupil Reasoning:



Viet Minh logistical supply lines; ordinary peasants used modified bicycles to carry heavy artillery up mountains surrounding Dien Bien Phu.

Prior to the mid-1950s, Vietnam was part of the French empire, but a nationalist and communist rebellion challenged colonial rule:

- **French Rule & Viet Minh:** Before the Second World War, Vietnam was part of the French empire (known as French Indochina). After the war, a communist independence movement known as the **Viet Minh**, led by **Ho Chi Minh**, began fighting to kick the French out of the country.
- **US Financial Backing:** Because **Ho Chi Minh** was a communist, the USA viewed the Viet Minh as a major threat and paid for a massive portion (**80%**) of the French war effort to try and stop them.
- **Dien Bien Phu (1954):** Despite heavy US financial backing, the French army suffered a crushing and humiliating defeat by the Viet Minh at the Battle of **Dien Bien Phu** in May 1954. This disaster forced France to withdraw entirely, ending French colonial rule in Vietnam.
- **The Geneva Accords (1954):** Following the French defeat, a peace conference produced the Geneva Accords. This agreement temporarily divided Vietnam in half along the **17th Parallel**. The North was controlled by the communist **Ho Chi Minh**, while the South was ruled by a non-communist, US-backed leader named **Ngo Dinh Diem**.
- **Elections Refused:** The agreement promised that nationwide elections would be held in 1956 to reunite the country, but the USA and Diem refused to hold them, knowing **Ho Chi Minh** would easily win.

> 🎓 **Scholarly Perspective: NSC-68 and the Roots of Intervention:** The Domino Theory was rooted in National Security Council Report 68 (NSC-68), a classified 1950 policy paper. NSC-68 argued that the Soviet Union was engaged in a global, monolithic conspiracy for world domination. This framework led US policymakers to view local anti-colonial struggles, like **Ho Chi Minh**'s nationalist movement against the French, as Soviet-directed aggression rather than local struggles for independence. > 🎙️ **Eyewitness Testimony — Thich Thien Hao:** "I watched as brother Quang Duc sat in the lotus position in the middle of the street. Another monk poured gasoline over him. He struck a match and was instantly enveloped in flames. He did not cry out, nor did he move a muscle. The air was thick with the smell of burning flesh, and the crowd around him began to weep and bow down. He burned for ten minutes before falling. He did this so the world would see the unbearable oppression of the Diem regime against the Buddhist majority."

Context: A Buddhist monk and eyewitness to the self-immolation of Thich Quang Duc in Saigon on June 11, 1963.

💬 **Reflective Question:** What does this extreme act of protest reveal about the intensity of Buddhist opposition to Diem? How did this impact US support for Diem?

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q1)

Along which parallel did the 1954 Geneva Accords temporarily divide Vietnam into North and South?

- [ ] A. 17th Parallel
- [ ] B. 38th Parallel
- [ ] C. 10th Parallel
- [ ] D. 45th Parallel

Think-Pair-Share: Q2 How did the US Domino Theory justify supporting Ngo Dinh Diem despite his undemocratic policies?

1. My Thoughts (Think)	2. Partner's Thoughts (Pair)



South Vietnamese President Ngo Dinh Diem in a motorcade; backed by US financial aid to prevent a communist election victory.

Following partition, the US government justified its intervention through global containment theories:

- **The Domino Theory:** President Dwight D. Eisenhower justified deeper US involvement in Vietnam using the **'Domino Theory'**. He argued that if South Vietnam was allowed to fall to communism, neighbouring countries like Laos, Cambodia, Thailand, and potentially even India, would inevitably fall one after the other, just like a row of dominoes.
- **Diem's Weaknesses — Corruption and Nepotism:** To prevent the dominoes from falling, Eisenhower heavily supported **Ngo Dinh Diem**'s government in South Vietnam. However, Diem was an incredibly weak and unpopular leader. He ruled as a dictator, gave all the top government jobs to his own family members, and took land away from poor peasants.
- **Diem's Weaknesses — Religious Persecution:** Diem was a strict Catholic ruling a country that was overwhelmingly Buddhist. He heavily discriminated against the Buddhist majority, leading to widespread anger.
- **Rise of the Vietcong:** Because Diem was so hated, many South Vietnamese peasants began supporting the communist rebels in the South, who became known as the **Vietcong**.
- **Eisenhower's Action:** To prop up Diem's failing government, Eisenhower sent millions of dollars, weapons, and a small number of US military **'advisors'** to train the South Vietnamese Army (ARVN).

> 🎓 **Scholarly Perspective: Diem's Social Base:** Historians point out that Diem's regime relied almost entirely on Catholic refugees who fled from the North after 1954, urban elites, and large landowners. By returning land to landlords that the Viet Minh had previously distributed to peasants, Diem alienated the rural majority, creating the very grievances the Vietcong exploited.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q3)

Why did Ngo Dinh Diem cancel the nationwide democratic elections scheduled for 1956?

- [ ] A. He knew Ho Chi Minh would win overwhelmingly (estimated 80% of votes)
- [ ] B. The United Nations ordered him to do so
- [ ] C. North Vietnam refused to participate
- [ ] D. There were no opposition candidates



Buddhist monk Thich Quang Duc self-immolates in Saigon in June 1963 in protest against religious persecution by Diem's regime.

When **John F. Kennedy** became President in 1961, the situation in South Vietnam was deteriorating rapidly as the Vietcong took control of the countryside:

- **Kennedy's Escalation:** Kennedy drastically increased the number of US military 'advisors' in Vietnam, raising the total from around **900** to **16,000** by 1963. He also deployed elite US Special Forces (the **'Green Berets'**) and authorised the use of chemical defoliants (like **Agent Orange**) to destroy the jungle cover used by the Vietcong.
- **The Strategic Hamlet Program (1962):** To cut off the Vietcong from their peasant supporters, Kennedy and Diem launched the Strategic Hamlet Program, forcibly moving South Vietnamese peasants into fortified camps surrounded by barbed wire and armed guards.
- **Failure of Hamlets:** The program was a total disaster. Peasants deeply resented being forced off their sacred ancestral lands and treated like prisoners. Corrupt officials failed to provide enough food, which drove even more starving and angry peasants into the arms of the Vietcong.
- **The Overthrow of Diem (1963):** In 1963, Diem's persecution of Buddhists triggered a crisis, highlighted by Buddhist monk **Thích Quảng Đức** burning himself to death on a Saigon street. Realising Diem was too corrupt to win, the Kennedy administration gave a 'green light' to South Vietnamese generals. On 1 November 1963, a coup was launched; Diem and his brother were overthrown and assassinated, plunging the country into a chaotic period of weak, constantly changing military governments.

📝 Revision Task

To check your understanding of this topic, complete the following in your study notes:

- Write down the definition of the Domino Theory.
- List two specific reasons why the Strategic Hamlet Program backfired and increased support for the Vietcong.

> 📝 **Context Focus: Overthrow of Diem** The coup against Diem occurred just weeks before President Kennedy's own assassination. Diem's death did not improve stability; instead, a succession of military rulers weakened South Vietnam further. > 🎓 **Scholarly Perspective: Strategic Hamlets as Peasant Relocation:** Historians argue that the Strategic Hamlet Program was fundamentally flawed because it ignored Vietnamese cultural ties to their ancestral land. Forcing peasants to leave their family graves and rice fields destroyed their loyalty to Saigon, driving them directly into alliances with the Vietcong.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q4)

What controversial US-backed program forcibly relocated South Vietnamese peasants into fortified villages surrounded by barbed wire?

- [ ] A. Strategic Hamlets Program
- [ ] B. Operation Rolling Thunder
- [ ] C. Search and Destroy
- [ ] D. Vietnamization

Pair & Share Activity

Q5. What does this extreme act of protest reveal about the intensity of Buddhist opposition to Diem? How did this impact US support for Diem?

Active Tasks

Q6. Give two things you can infer from Source A about the Strategic Hamlet Program in Vietnam. (4 marks)

Q7. How did the US Domino Theory justify supporting Ngo Dinh Diem despite his undemocratic policies?

Q8. Why did Diem's favoritism toward Catholicism alienate the majority Buddhist population in South Vietnam?

Historian's Corner: ⚖️ Dual Interpretation: Support for Ngo Dinh Diem

Q9. Which historical interpretation provides a more convincing explanation of developments in KT 3.1: Why did the US support the unpopular government of Ngo Dinh Diem in South Vietnam??

Source A

Source A: A photograph showing President Ngo Dinh Diem reviewing a military parade in Saigon, October 1957.

[A photograph of Diem standing in an open-top car, reviewing rows of South Vietnamese soldiers who are carrying US-supplied weapons. US advisers are standing nearby in civilian clothes.]

Source B

Source B: A photograph of Buddhist demonstrations in Saigon against President Diem's government, June 1963.

[A photograph showing a massive crowd of Buddhist monks and nuns sitting in a street, holding banners reading 'Stop Religious Persecution!' and blocking traffic. Police are surrounding the crowd.]

Provenance Scaffolding:

Scaffolding Clue: Evaluate the author, audience, and motive for both sources. For written accounts, consider if the author has political reasons to justify their actions. For photographs, consider what may be excluded outside the camera's frame.

Q10. How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the unpopularity and collapse of Ngo Dinh Diem's regime in South Vietnam? (8 marks)

L2: KT 3.2: Why did the US send combat troops to Vietnam after the Gulf of Tonkin incident?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Demonstrate comprehensive historical knowledge of the key developments and figures in KT 3.2: Why did the US send combat troops to Vietnam after the Gulf of Tonkin incident?.
- [ ] Analyse conflicting motivations, tactics, and responses of groups and individuals involved in the crisis.
- [ ] Evaluate competing historical interpretations and source evidence to construct reasoned causal judgments for Paper 3.

Recall & Retrieval

1. Why was Vietnam temporarily divided at the 17th parallel in 1954?

2. What is Eisenhower's 'Domino Theory'?

3. Why was Ngo Dinh Diem's government unpopular in South Vietnam?

4. Which laws enforced racial segregation and discrimination in the Southern states in the 1950s?

5. What does the abbreviation NAACP stand for?

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: *Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):*

Gulf of Tonkin Resolution | March 1965 | 1964 | Operation Rolling Thunder | Lyndon B. Johnson

Teacher Model / Pupil Sentence:



A US infantryman cautiously patrols a murky swamp in South Vietnam, where Vietcong guerrillas blended into the local rural population.

When Johnson took office, the South Vietnamese government was on the verge of collapse, making the communist Vietcong a more dangerous threat than ever before:

- **Political Chaos in the South:** Following the assassination of President Diem in 1963, South Vietnam suffered from extreme political instability. One weak military government was toppled by another in a series of constant coups, meaning the South Vietnamese leaders were too busy fighting each other to effectively fight the communists.
- **Vietcong Successes:** Taking advantage of this chaos, the Vietcong (supported by the North Vietnamese Army) gained massive ground. By 1964, they controlled roughly **35%** of South Vietnam and were inflicting heavy defeats on the South Vietnamese Army (ARVN) in conventional battles, such as at Binh Gia.
- **Attacks on Americans:** The Vietcong began directly and aggressively targeting American military installations and personnel. In November 1964, they attacked the US airbase at Bien Hoa, and in February 1965, they launched a deadly raid on a US base at Pleiku, killing **8 Americans** and destroying **10 aircraft**.

> 🎓 **Scholarly Perspective: Binh Gia and Conventional Shift:** Historians point to the Battle of Binh Gia (December 1964) as a crucial moment. For the first time, the Vietcong deployed full regiments and defeated elite ARVN forces in a conventional, multi-day battle. This proved to US observers that the Vietcong was no longer just a small-scale guerrilla band but an organized army capable of defeating South Vietnam. > 🎙️ **Eyewitness Testimony — James Stockdale:** "I had the best seat in the house from my cockpit, flying low over the destroyers Maddox and Turner Joy in the pitch black. I was ordered to look for North Vietnamese PT boats attacking our ships. I fired my guns where the sonar men said the targets were, but there was nothing there. No boats, no wakes, no gunfire from the Vietnamese. It was just our own ships shooting at ghost targets on their radars. When I landed, I was told we were launching retaliatory airstrikes for an 'attack' that I knew had never happened."

Context: US Navy pilot flying over the Gulf of Tonkin on the night of August 4, 1964.

💬 **Reflective Question:** If the second Gulf of Tonkin attack was a 'ghost' event, how does this affect the moral and political justification for the US escalation of the war?

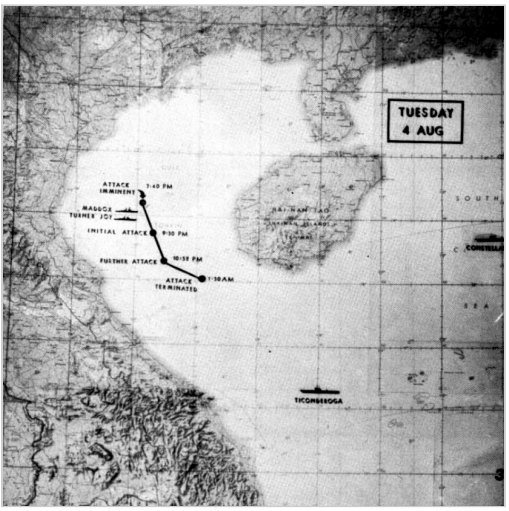
KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q1)

What was the political and guerrilla organisation fighting against the US and South Vietnamese government?

- [ ] A. The Vietcong (National Liberation Front)
- [ ] B. The ARVN
- [ ] C. The Green Berets
- [ ] D. The SEATO Alliance

Think-Pair-Share: Q2 Why was the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution called a 'blank check' for President Johnson?

1. My Thoughts (Think)	2. Partner's Thoughts (Pair)



The destroyer USS Maddox, allegedly attacked by North Vietnamese torpedo boats in the Gulf of Tonkin in August 1964.

To save South Vietnam, Johnson needed to escalate US military action, but he needed a legal reason and public support. A controversial event at sea provided his administration with the pretext:

- **The First Attack (2 August 1964):** The US warship **USS Maddox**, conducting an intelligence-gathering mission, was approached and fired upon by three North Vietnamese torpedo boats in the Gulf of Tonkin. The Maddox returned fire and drove them off.
- **The 'Phantom' Second Attack (4 August 1964):** During a heavy storm, the crews of the Maddox and another ship, the Turner Joy, reported they were under a second torpedo attack.
- **The Declassified Truth:** It was later revealed that this second attack never actually happened. The reports were the result of bad weather, confused radar operators, and panic. However, President Johnson and his Secretary of Defense, **Robert McNamara**, ignored these doubts and told the US public that American ships had been the victims of *"unprovoked aggression"*.

> 🎓 **Scholarly Perspective: OPLAN 34A and Provocation:** While the US public was told the Maddox was on a routine patrol, declassified records show it was supporting OPLAN 34A—secret South Vietnamese commando raids on North Vietnamese coastal facilities. Hanoi's torpedo attacks were retaliation for these raids, showing the US was actively involved in provocative acts.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q3)

What congressional resolution in August 1964 gave President Johnson authority to 'take all necessary measures' in Vietnam?

- [ ] A. The Gulf of Tonkin Resolution
- [ ] B. The War Powers Act
- [ ] C. The Geneva Accord
- [ ] D. The Truman Doctrine



Secretary of Defense Robert McNamara uses maps during a Pentagon press briefing on airstrikes against North Vietnam, 1965.

The incident at sea provided the immediate catalyst for full-scale US military escalation:

- **The "Blank Check":** Using the Gulf of Tonkin incident to spark outrage, Johnson asked Congress for the power to retaliate. On 7 August 1964, Congress overwhelmingly passed the **Gulf of Tonkin Resolution**.
- **Significance:** This resolution gave the President the power to take *"all necessary measures"* to repel armed attacks and prevent further aggression in Southeast Asia. It effectively allowed Johnson to wage a full-scale war without Congress ever officially declaring war.
- **The Bombing Campaign:** Armed with this new power, and provoked by the Pleiku attack, Johnson launched **Operation Rolling Thunder** in early 1965—a massive, sustained bombing campaign against North Vietnam.
- **Marines Land at Da Nang (March 1965):** Shortly after, in March 1965, the first official US ground combat troops (**3,500 Marines**) waded ashore at Da Nang. By the time Johnson left office in 1969, over **500,000** American troops were deployed in Vietnam.

> 🎓 **Scholarly Perspective: The Shift to Combat:** Historians emphasize that the landing of the Marines at Da Nang changed the entire character of the war. Once combat troops were committed, US prestige became directly tied to the outcome, making it politically impossible to withdraw without looking defeated, which drove a continuous cycle of reinforcements.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q4)

What was the sustained aerial bombardment campaign against North Vietnam launched by LBJ in 1965 called?

- [ ] A. Operation Rolling Thunder

- [ ] B. Search and Destroy
- [ ] C. Operation Linebacker
- [ ] D. Strategic Hamlets



US Marines wade ashore at Da Nang in March 1965, marking the start of direct American combat troop involvement in Vietnam.

Aside from the immediate threat of the Vietcong and the Tonkin incident, Johnson's escalation was driven by deep-rooted Cold War fears:

- **The Domino Theory and Containment:** Like Eisenhower and Kennedy, Johnson firmly believed that if South Vietnam fell to communism, neighbouring countries would inevitably fall too, just like a row of dominoes.
- **Personal and National Credibility:** Johnson was deeply concerned about America's reputation and his own political standing. He felt that withdrawing would make the USA look weak and untrustworthy to its global allies.
- **Domestic Politics:** Facing a presidential election in 1964, Johnson did not want to be accused by Republican rivals of being *"soft on communism"* or be remembered as the President who *"lost"* Vietnam.

📝 Revision Task

To check your understanding of this topic, complete the following in your study notes:

- Explain in your own words how the events in the Gulf of Tonkin in August 1964 led directly to the passing of the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution.
- Describe the specific power this Resolution gave to President Johnson.

> 🎓 **Scholarly Perspective: The Credibility Trap:** Cold War historians argue that Johnson became trapped by the rhetoric of US credibility. By framing the defense of South Vietnam as a test of American global resolve, the administration made any compromise look like surrender, committing the nation to a war of attrition where the political cost of losing was always deemed higher than the military cost of escalating.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q5)

How many US combat troops were stationed in Vietnam at the peak of American escalation in late 1968?

- [ ] A. Over 536,000 troops
- [ ] B. 50,000 troops
- [ ] C. 16,000 troops
- [ ] D. 1 million troops

Pair & Share Activity

Q6. If the second Gulf of Tonkin attack was a 'ghost' event, how does this affect the moral and political justification for the US escalation of the war?

Active Tasks

Q7. Explain why US military involvement in Vietnam escalated in the years 1964–68. (12 marks)

Q8. Why was the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution called a 'blank check' for President Johnson?

Q9. How did the transition from 'advisory' status to combat deployment in March 1965 change the nature of the war?

Historian's Corner: ⚖️ Dual Interpretation: Gulf of Tonkin Resolution

Q10. Which historical interpretation provides a more convincing explanation of developments in KT 3.2: Why did the US send combat troops to Vietnam after the Gulf of Tonkin incident??

Source A

Source A: From a photograph of the destroyer USS Maddox sailing in the Gulf of Tonkin, August 1964.

[A photograph showing the US warship USS Maddox traveling through calm seas. Radar antennas are rotating, and gun turrets are aimed toward the horizon.]

Source B

Source B: From a photograph of US Marines landing at Da Nang beach, South Vietnam, 8 March 1965.

[A photograph of US Marines carrying heavy backpacks and rifles wading through shallow water onto a sandy beach. Local Vietnamese women are handing them flower garlands as they land.]

Provenance Scaffolding:

Scaffolding Clue: Evaluate the author, audience, and motive for both sources. For written accounts, consider if the author has political reasons to justify their actions. For photographs, consider what may be excluded outside the camera's frame.

Q11. How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the escalation of US involvement and the deployment of combat troops to Vietnam? (8 marks)

L3: KT 3.3: Why did US military tactics (like bombing and search & destroy) fail to defeat the Vietcong?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Demonstrate comprehensive historical knowledge of the key developments and figures in KT 3.3: Why did US military tactics (like bombing and search & destroy) fail to defeat the Vietcong?.
- [ ] Analyse conflicting motivations, tactics, and responses of groups and individuals involved in the crisis.
- [ ] Evaluate competing historical interpretations and source evidence to construct reasoned causal judgments for Paper 3.

Recall & Retrieval

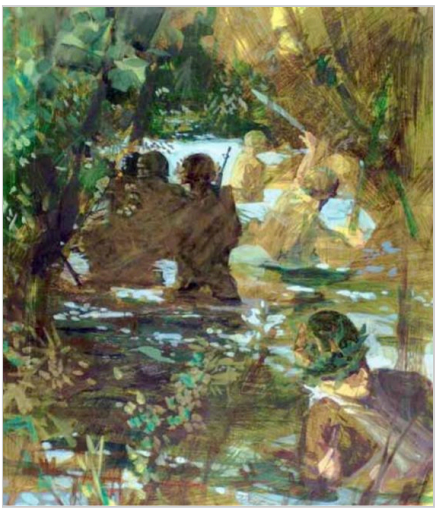
1. **What was the Gulf of Tonkin incident in August 1964?**
2. **What authority did the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution give to President Johnson?**
3. **What was the goal of Operation Rolling Thunder?**
4. **Which laws enforced racial segregation and discrimination in the Southern states in the 1950s?**
5. **What does the abbreviation NAACP stand for?**

Vocabulary Check

Conceptual Classification: *Categorise the terms from the word bank into the two historical boxes below:*

Agent Orange | Ho Chi Minh Trail | Ho Chi Minh Trail | Agent Orange | Napalm

Power, Governance & Warfare	Economy, Trade & Society



US soldiers struggle through thick, booby-trapped jungle terrain searching for hidden Vietcong tunnel complexes.

The Vietcong (VC) knew they could not defeat the technologically advanced US military in open, pitched battles. Instead, they relied on their deep knowledge of the local jungle terrain and used guerrilla warfare to wear down American morale:

- **Hit-and-Run and Ambushes:** The VC followed strict principles: retreat when the enemy attacks, raid when the enemy camps, and attack when the enemy tires. They never engaged in direct conventional battles, instead picking off enemy soldiers in ambushes before quickly disappearing into the jungle.
- **'Hanging onto the Belts':** To counter America's massive advantage in air power and artillery, VC fighters stayed as close to US troops as possible during firefights. By engaging at such close quarters, the Americans could not call in bombing strikes for fear of hitting their own men.
- **The Invisible Enemy:** VC fighters did not wear military uniforms. They dressed in everyday clothing so they could hide in plain sight, making it nearly impossible for US soldiers to distinguish between innocent civilian peasants and the enemy.
- **Booby Traps:** Around **11% to 19%** of all US casualties were caused by cheap, terrifying booby traps. The most common were **punji sticks** (sharpened bamboo stakes hidden in shallow, camouflaged pits, often smeared with excrement to cause infection), tripwires, and 'Bouncing Betty' mines that exploded at waist height.
- **Tunnel Networks:** The VC constructed hundreds of miles of complex underground tunnels, such as those at **Cu Chi**. These multi-level networks contained barracks, hospitals, and weapons factories, protecting them from US bombing and allowing them to move completely undetected.
- **The Ho Chi Minh Trail:** To keep their fighters armed, the VC relied on a **15,000km network** of jungle paths known as the **Ho Chi Minh** Trail, which ran from North Vietnam through neutral Laos and Cambodia to secretly deliver Soviet and Chinese weapons to the South.

> 🎓 **Scholarly Perspective: Vietcong Logistics and Resilience:** Revisionist historians argue that the US completely underestimated the logistic resilience of the Vietcong. The **Ho Chi Minh** Trail, despite constant US bombing, remained open because thousands of volunteers repaired the damage immediately, showing the national commitment to reunification. > 🎙️ **Eyewitness Testimony — Nguyen Thi Binh:** “We lived like rats under the ground. The tunnels of Cu Chi were dark, damp, and crawled with centipedes and scorpions. When the Americans bombed, the earth shook and dirt fell in our eyes. But we stayed. We learned to cook without smoke and walk without leaving footprints. We waited until the American soldiers walked past, then we would pop up, fire, and disappear into the ground. They had tanks and helicopters, but they could not fight what they could not see.”

Context: A female Vietcong guerrilla fighter, interviewed about surviving search-and-destroy missions in the Cu Chi tunnels.

💬 **Reflective Question:** How did the Vietcong use the tunnels and hit-and-run tactics to render the US military's technological superiority ineffective?

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q1)

What cheap, deadly booby trap did the Vietcong construct using sharpened bamboo smeared with poison or dung?

- [ ] A. Punji stick pit
- [ ] B. Claymore mine
- [ ] C. Bouncing Betty
- [ ] D. Tripwire grenade

Think-Pair-Share: Q2 Why did the US reliance on 'body counts' as a measure of success distort the actual progress of the war?

1. My Thoughts (Think)	2. Partner's Thoughts (Pair)



US Air Force C-123 aircraft spray Agent Orange chemical defoliant over South Vietnamese forest canopy in Operation Ranch Hand.

The US military strategy relied heavily on their massive superiority in firepower, mobility (helicopters), and technology, aiming to force the communists into battles where a high 'body count' would ensure victory:

- **Operation Rolling Thunder (1965–1968):** In March 1965, the US launched a massive, sustained strategic bombing campaign against North Vietnam to destroy its industrial base and cut off the **Ho Chi Minh** Trail. It was largely a failure because North Vietnam was a pre-industrial nation with few factories, crucial war supplies came from China and the USSR (which the US could not bomb for fear of starting WW3), and the VC constantly repaired the trail.
- **Search and Destroy:** Using helicopters to fly platoons into hostile areas to search out and destroy VC camps. If a village was suspected of supporting the VC, troops would destroy it, often burning thatched homes to the ground (known as **'Zippo raids'**). This tactic failed to win 'hearts and minds', resulted in high civilian casualties, and allowed the VC to simply move back in once US helicopters left.
- **Chemical Weapons (Agent Orange & Napalm):** To strip jungle cover and destroy crops, the US sprayed over **20 million gallons** of **Agent Orange** (highly toxic weedkiller), causing long-term health issues and birth defects. They also dropped bombs containing **napalm**, a highly flammable petroleum jelly that stuck to skin and burned at **800°C** to the bone, causing massive international outrage and fueling the anti-war movement.

> 🎓 **Scholarly Perspective: Failure of Firepower:** Traditional historians argue that US military tactics were fundamentally flawed because they relied on heavy conventional firepower. This was counterproductive in a counterinsurgency war, as civilian casualties and crop destruction alienated the rural populace, driving them to support the Vietcong.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q3)

What tactic, devised by General Westmoreland, used helicopters to locate and kill Vietcong before leaving the area?

- [ ] A. Search and Destroy
- [ ] B. Strategic Hamlets
- [ ] C. Operation Rolling Thunder
- [ ] D. Pacification



Huey helicopters deploy American airborne infantry into battle zones during the fierce house-to-house fighting of the Tet Offensive, 1968.

In January 1968, the Vietcong and North Vietnamese forces launched a massive surprise attack during the Tet holiday, changing the course of the war:

- **The Surprise Attack:** On 30–31 January 1968, during the 'Tet' (Lunar New Year) holiday ceasefire, over **84,000 Vietcong and North Vietnamese troops** launched a massive, highly coordinated surprise attack across South Vietnam, hitting over 100 towns, cities, and bases.
- **The US Embassy:** In a deeply shocking event, a suicide squad of VC guerrillas breached the walls of the US Embassy in Saigon, fighting American forces on the grounds.
- **A Military Disaster for the VC:** The VC failed to spark a civilian uprising, suffered between **37,000 and 58,000 casualties**, and was virtually wiped out as an effective fighting force on the ground.
- **A Political Defeat for the USA:** Seeing live television footage of the fighting created a massive **'credibility gap'**. Highly respected CBS anchor **Walter Cronkite** declared the war an unwinnable stalemate. Facing protests, President Johnson halted bombing and announced he would not seek re-election.

📝 Revision Task: The Turning Point

To check your understanding of the Tet Offensive, complete the following in your study notes:

- Define the tactic **'Hanging onto the belts'**.

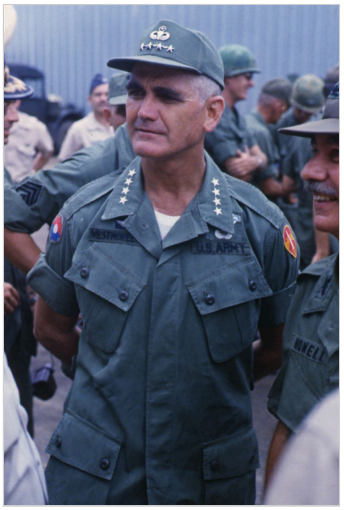
- Explain in two sentences why the Tet Offensive is considered a military victory for the USA but a political disaster.

> 📝 **Context Focus: Tet Offensive** Tet was a military victory for the US, but a political defeat. It proved that the Vietcong could still launch a massive coordinated attack despite years of US intervention. > 🎓 **Scholarly Perspective: Walter Cronkite's Broadcast:** Following the Tet Offensive, legendary CBS news anchor Walter Cronkite declared the war was 'mired in stalemate'. Historians note that President Johnson famously remarked, 'If I've lost Cronkite, I've lost Middle America,' highlighting the profound domestic impact of the media's reaction to Tet.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q4)

During the 1968 Tet Offensive, what highly fortified American diplomatic compound in Saigon was temporarily penetrated by Vietcong commandos?

- [ ] A. The US Embassy
- [ ] B. The White House
- [ ] C. Tan Son Nhut Airbase
- [ ] D. The Presidential Palace



General William Westmoreland, commander of US forces, claimed the military was winning a war of attrition right before Tet struck.

Historians and observers analyze the nature of the conflict and its turning points through differing perspectives:

Interpretation A: The Dissenting Advisor (George Ball, 1964)

"The political situation in Saigon is progressively deteriorating... there seems little likelihood of establishing a government that can conduct effective military operations. By injecting substantial ground forces, we risk a progressive taking-over of the war. Once on the 'tiger's back' we cannot be sure of picking the place to dismount."

Interpretation B: The Ground-Level Reality (The Soldier’s Perspective)

"The missions were incredibly risky; you didn't know if your next step would be your last because of mines. When we moved through a village, our soldiers would burn down houses even though they weren't supposed to. Despite the power of Operation Rolling Thunder, which stretched from weeks into years, the bombing failed to stop the enemy or break their will."

Interpretation C: The Political Realist (The Post-Tet View)

"The Tet Offensive revealed the patience and durability of the enemy. It convinced many that the cost of winning was out of proportion to U.S. interests. We realized we could not do what we wished to do because the enemy could replenish its manpower so easily, matching every escalation we made."

📝 Final Synthesis Tasks

Complete these synthesis tasks in your study notes to integrate the lessons from this topic:

- **AO2 Comparison Task:** Compare the Vietcong's strategy of "patience and resilience" with the U.S. "strategy of attrition." Explain which was better suited to the Vietnamese geography.
- **AO4 Synthesis Question:** Based on the three Interpretations provided, why did George Ball's 1964 warnings regarding the "deteriorating" political situation and the "tiger's back" prove accurate by 1968?
- **Concept Check (AO1):** Define these key terms from the worksheet:
    - *The Gulf of Tonkin Resolution*
    - *Vietnamisation*
    - *Asymmetric Warfare*

> 🎓 **Scholarly Perspective: Asymmetric Adaptation:** Modern strategic analysts refer to the Vietnam War as a classic study in asymmetric warfare. The United States relied on superior industrial capacity and firepower to force a swift decision, whereas the Democratic Republic of Vietnam and the National Liberation Front designed a protracted warfare model. This model prioritized political durability and human reserves over technology, allowing them to outlast the domestic political will of their opponent.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q5)

What legendary CBS news anchor visited Vietnam after the Tet Offensive and declared the war 'mired in stalemate'?

- [ ] A. Walter Cronkite
- [ ] B. Edward R. Murrow
- [ ] C. Dan Rather
- [ ] D. David Brinkley

Pair & Share Activity

Q6. How did the Vietcong use the tunnels and hit-and-run tactics to render the US military's technological superiority ineffective?

Active Tasks

Q7. How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into the nature of the conflict in Vietnam? (8 marks)

Q8. Why did the US reliance on 'body counts' as a measure of success distort the actual progress of the war?

Q9. How did chemical defoliants like Agent Orange backfire against the US goal of winning 'hearts and minds'?

Historian's Corner: ⚖️ Dual Interpretation: Military Tactics in Vietnam

Q10. Which historical interpretation provides a more convincing explanation of developments in KT 3.3: Why did US military tactics (like bombing and search & destroy) fail to defeat the Vietcong??

Source A

Source A: From a photograph showing a US soldier patrolling on foot in a swampy jungle, 1967.

[A photograph of a US soldier wading waist-deep through muddy swamp water in dense jungle. He is holding his M16 rifle high above the water and looks tense and exhausted.]

Source B

Source B: From a photograph showing US Air Force C-123 planes spraying defoliants over a forest, 1966.

[A photograph showing three C-123 military transport planes flying in formation at low altitude, releasing thick white chemical trails of Agent Orange over dense green forest canopy.]

Provenance Scaffolding:

Scaffolding Clue: Evaluate the author, audience, and motive for both sources. For written accounts, consider if the author has political reasons to justify their actions. For photographs, consider what may be excluded outside the camera's frame.

Q11. How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the tactics used by the US military in the Vietnam War? (8 marks)

L4: KT 3.4: What was Nixon's 'Vietnamization' policy, and did it achieve peace with honour?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Demonstrate comprehensive historical knowledge of the key developments and figures in KT 3.4: What was Nixon's 'Vietnamization' policy, and did it achieve peace with honour?.
- [ ] Analyse conflicting motivations, tactics, and responses of groups and individuals involved in the crisis.
- [ ] Evaluate competing historical interpretations and source evidence to construct reasoned causal judgments for Paper 3.

Recall & Retrieval

1. What was the purpose of 'Search and Destroy' missions?

2. Why did the US military use chemical weapons like Agent Orange and Napalm?

3. What is the guerrilla warfare strategy used by the Vietcong?

4. Which laws enforced racial segregation and discrimination in the Southern states in the 1950s?

5. What does the abbreviation NAACP stand for?

Vocabulary Check

Spot the Deliberate Error: *Read the statement below. One historical fact or vocabulary concept has been deliberately falsified. Underline the error and explain the accurate historical reality below:*

Vietnamization | Cambodia | Vietnamisation | 1973 | Henry Kissinger

Challenge: Write ONE statement containing a deliberate historical misconception using **Vietnamization** or **Cambodia**. Identify and correct the error:

Teacher Model / Historical Correction:



President Richard Nixon visits American infantrymen in Vietnam in July 1969 as he began phased troop withdrawals.

Elected in 1968 on the promise of bringing 'peace with honor', President **Richard Nixon** introduced a new Cold War strategy to reduce direct American combat involvement:

- **The Nixon Doctrine (1969):** Outlined in July 1969, this doctrine fundamentally changed US strategy. Nixon stated that the USA would honor its defence commitments and support allies against communism with financial aid and military equipment, but would no longer provide American combat troops.
- **Troop Withdrawals:** Following this doctrine, Nixon began the gradual withdrawal of US troops, announcing the first withdrawal of **25,000 troops** in June 1969. This steadily reduced the US presence from its peak of over 500,000 men. By March 1973, the last American combat troops had completely withdrawn from Vietnam.

> 🎓 **Scholarly Perspective: Shift in Global Strategy:** Historians view the Nixon Doctrine as a realistic adjustment to the limits of American power exposed by the Vietnam War. Rather than trying to police the world with ground troops, the US shifted to a strategy of supporting regional powers to defend themselves, a policy that marked a significant retreat from the expansive containment policies of the early Cold War. > 🎙️ **Eyewitness Testimony — ARVN Soldier:** "The Americans told us we were ready to fight alone. They gave us their M16 rifles and their tanks, and then they told us to cross the border into Laos to cut the **Ho Chi Minh** trail. But once we crossed, we met massive North Vietnamese artillery and tanks. The Americans provided air support, but it wasn't enough. We were slaughtered. Our commanders panicked and fled. I saw soldiers clinging to the skids of departing American helicopters just to escape. We were not ready, and we knew it."

Context: A soldier in the South Vietnamese army, recalling the disastrous invasion of Laos (Operation Lam Son 719) in 1971.

💬 **Reflective Question:** What does this soldier's account of the Laos invasion tell us about the practical weaknesses and failures of Nixon's 'Vietnamization' policy?

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q1)

What was Nixon's core policy of gradually replacing US combat troops with trained South Vietnamese forces called?

- [ ] A. Vietnamization
- [ ] B. Pacification
- [ ] C. Search and Destroy
- [ ] D. Strategic Retrenchment

Think-Pair-Share: Q2 What was the core contradiction in Nixon's policy of Vietnamization?

1. My Thoughts (Think)	2. Partner's Thoughts (Pair)



FAIRFAX Operation, Gia Dinh province. An integrated US-ARVN combat team heading back to base camp after an all-night ambush patrol.

South Vietnamese ARVN troops advance under fire; despite billions in US weaponry, ARVN remained crippled by corruption and poor leadership.

Vietnamisation was the practical application of the Nixon Doctrine in Vietnam, aiming to shift the burden of war to the local forces:

- **Key Features:** The primary goal was to allow American troops to withdraw without looking like they had been defeated, by shifting the entire burden of fighting onto the South Vietnamese Army (ARVN). The US provided extensive training and millions of dollars in modern equipment, including aircraft, tanks, artillery, and anti-tank weaponry.
- **ARVN Weaknesses:** Despite the new equipment, the ARVN lacked the necessary expertise and leadership to defeat the North Vietnamese. Desertion was highly common among South Vietnamese troops when faced with Vietcong attacks.
- **Collapsing US Morale:** As withdrawal progressed, remaining US troops lost the will to fight. Discipline rapidly declined, leading to severe drug abuse (with around **35,000 soldiers** addicted to heroin) and a sharp rise in **'fragging'** (the murder of US officers by their own disgruntled soldiers).
- **Dependency on the USA:** The policy proved that the South Vietnamese government and military were fundamentally too weak to stand on their own. North Vietnamese leaders realised that the anti-war protests in America would eventually force a total US withdrawal, leaving the ARVN highly vulnerable without US air support.

> 🎓 **Scholarly Perspective: Why Vietnamisation Failed:** Historians identify that Vietnamisation failed because the ARVN lacked political motivation and was built in the image of the US Army—dependent on expensive technology, air power, and fuel. When the US withdrew its direct support, South Vietnam could not sustain this style of warfare.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q3)

Which disastrous 1971 military operation in Laos demonstrated that ARVN could not defeat North Vietnamese forces without US troops?

- [ ] A. Operation Lam Son 719
- [ ] B. Operation Rolling Thunder
- [ ] C. Operation Linebacker
- [ ] D. Search and Destroy



President Nixon points to a map of Cambodia during a live televised address explaining the US military incursion, April 1970.

Despite his promises to de-escalate, Nixon recognised that the Vietcong relied on the **Ho Chi Minh** Trail running through neutral countries, leading him to expand the war:

- **Cambodia (1970):** In 1969, Nixon ordered a secret bombing campaign (**Operation Menu**) against communist sanctuaries in Cambodia. When this failed to stop supplies, Nixon sent **30,000 US and ARVN ground troops** across the border in the spring of 1970.
- **Significance of Cambodia:** While the troops destroyed communist bases, the invasion caused massive public outrage in America, sparking nationwide university protests that famously led to the **Kent State University shootings**, where National Guardsmen killed four protesting students. In response, Congress repealed the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution to restrict the President's war powers.
- **Laos (1971):** Because Congress banned Nixon from sending US ground troops into neighbouring countries, the invasion of Laos in February 1971 (**Operation Lam Son 719**) was conducted by **5,000 elite ARVN troops**, supported only by US aircraft.
- **Significance of Laos:** The ARVN faced fierce resistance from well-equipped North Vietnamese forces and were soundly defeated, retreating with heavy casualties. This humiliating defeat publicly proved that the ARVN could not fight effectively, highlighting the failure of Vietnamisation.

> 📑 **Nixon's Strategy** Understand the double-sided nature of Nixon's policy. He withdrew ground troops to appease US voters, but increased air bombing and invaded Cambodia to keep South Vietnam from collapsing. > 🎓 **Scholarly Perspective: The Cooper-Church Amendment:** Nixon's invasion of Cambodia

in 1970 provoked a constitutional showdown. In response, Congress passed the Cooper-Church Amendment. This historic legislation prohibited the funding of US ground troops or advisers in Cambodia and Laos, representing the first time Congress had used its power of the purse to limit presidential military actions during the Vietnam War.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q4)

What was the secret code name for the 14-month US B-52 carpet-bombing of communist bases inside Cambodia?

- [ ] A. Operation Menu
- [ ] B. Operation Rolling Thunder
- [ ] C. Operation Linebacker
- [ ] D. Operation Ranch Hand



Representatives of the United States, North Vietnam, South Vietnam, and the Vietcong sign the Paris Peace Accords, January 1973.

In desperation to force North Vietnam to surrender, Nixon launched major bombing campaigns:

- **The Easter Offensive:** In March 1972, North Vietnam launched a massive conventional invasion of the South known as the Easter Offensive. The ARVN were nearly overrun and only survived because of massive US air support.
- **Operation Linebacker:** In response, Nixon launched Operation Linebacker, resuming the heavy, unrestricted bombing of North Vietnam to disrupt their supply lines from China and the USSR.
- **The Christmas Bombings (Linebacker II):** By autumn 1972, peace talks in Paris had stalled because South Vietnam's President Thieu refused to sign the agreement. To force North Vietnam to accept US concessions, Nixon ordered **Operation Linebacker II** in December 1972.
- **Significance of Linebacker II:** Over 12 days, B-52 bombers dropped **20,000 tons of explosives** on Hanoi and the port city of Haiphong. This relentless campaign killed over 1,600 civilians and flattened North Vietnam's war industry, successfully pressuring North Vietnam to sign the Paris Peace Accords the following month.

📝 Revision Task: Changes under Nixon

To check your understanding of this topic, complete the following in your study notes:

- Explain why the policy of Vietnamisation failed to achieve 'peace with honour'.

- Summarize the military campaigns in Cambodia (1970), Laos (1971), and North Vietnam (1972), detailing their outcomes and significance.

> 🎓 **Scholarly Perspective: Madman Theory:** Nixon's heavy bombing campaigns, especially Linebacker II, were aligned with what he called the 'Madman Theory.' Nixon wanted to convince North Vietnamese and Soviet leaders that he was obsessed and would stop at nothing, including nuclear weapons or total destruction, to end the war, hoping this fear would force concessions at the bargaining table.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q5)

What was the 11-day B-52 bombing blitz on North Vietnam in December 1972 commonly called?

- [ ] A. The Christmas Bombings (Linebacker II)
- [ ] B. Operation Rolling Thunder
- [ ] C. The Tet Bombings
- [ ] D. Operation Menu

Pair & Share Activity

Q6. What does this soldier's account of the Laos invasion tell us about the practical weaknesses and failures of Nixon's 'Vietnamization' policy?

Active Tasks

Q7. Give two things you can infer from Source A about the domestic impact of the 1970 invasion of Cambodia. (4 marks)

Q8. What was the core contradiction in Nixon's policy of Vietnamization?

Q9. Why did the ARVN struggle to defend South Vietnam independently despite receiving massive US equipment?

Historian's Corner: ⚖️ Dual Interpretation: Nixon's Cambodia Invasion (1970)

Q10. Which historical interpretation provides a more convincing explanation of developments in KT 3.4: What was Nixon's 'Vietnamization' policy, and did it achieve peace with honour??

Source A

Source A: From a photograph of President Richard Nixon visiting US troops in South Vietnam, July 1969.

Source B

Source B: A photograph showing South Vietnamese ARVN troops advancing during the invasion of Cambodia, May 1970.

[A photograph showing President Nixon standing in a crowd of smiling US soldiers in combat uniforms. He is shaking hands and talking with them, projecting a positive image of troop support.]

[A photograph showing several ARVN soldiers running past a burning tank on a dirt road in Cambodia. Helicopters are flying overhead, and the soldiers are carrying M16 rifles.]

Provenance Scaffolding:

Scaffolding Clue: Evaluate the author, audience, and motive for both sources. For written accounts, consider if the author has political reasons to justify their actions. For photographs, consider what may be excluded outside the camera's frame.

Q11. How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the effectiveness of Nixon's policy of Vietnamization? (8 marks)